



MATTER OF FAITH:
In the service of
God and mankind

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printing press that revolutionised religious books was born due to a mistake. In the 1920s, devotees of Seth Jai Dayal Goyandka, a *Gita* preacher, suggested he publish his interpretations. The Vanik Press in Kolkata did so it but the version was full of mistakes. Goyandka was aghast and started thinking about setting up his own printing press. One of his pupils Ghan Shyam Jalan convinced him to start one at Gorakhpur, which was where Gita Press was first set up on April 29, 1923. Five months later, the first printing machine was bought for Rs 600. Now, the most recent purchase is that of a binding machine from Muller Martini, Germany, for Rs 1.25 crore. Goyandka and his colleague Hanuman Prasad Poddar who pioneered the publication of original Hindu scriptures and their interpretations, ensured that it would not become a profit-making publication. Instead, it aimed at propagating spiritual, religious and moral values.

While re-inventing the way India looked at spiri-

Re 1

is the price of the
cheapest book and
Rs 1,350 of the
most expensive one

6.34 cr

copies of the *Gita* and
6.49 crore copies of the
Ramcharitmanas have
been printed so far

tual and religious books, Gita Press also put a face to the deities. Poddar hired three artists to create illustrations of different deities for *Kalyan* and their other publications. Today there are more than 2,500 such illustrations in its archives. Critics like Namwar Singh say the images of deities created by artists B.K. Mitra, Jagannath and Bhagwan could have been based on Raja Ravi Varma's creations. However, Indologist and Sanskrit scholar Kalanath Shashtry strongly refutes this hypothesis. The press archives contain over 3,500 manuscripts including at least 100 interpretations of the *Gita*. It maintains high editorial standards and has had to dump books due to a single mistake.

Gita Press is a name that is now virtually engraved on the soul of spiritual India. It has become synonymous with a pioneer, a publishing house that re-introduced the scriptures, religious texts and the Vedas to people, taking it from the portals of temples to modern India's drawing rooms.